

# Communication Policy

## SECTION 1: PURPOSE

### 1 PURPOSE

The purpose of this Communication Policy is to ensure that all communication within Chosanta Management is clear, timely, respectful, and inclusive. Effective communication is essential to the delivery of high-quality care and support, and is fundamental to building trust and understanding between staff, residents, families, and stakeholders.

**This policy aims to:**

- ✓ Promote open and transparent communication within the service
- ✓ Ensure that residents' communication needs and preferences are recognised and supported
- ✓ Facilitate consistent communication practices among staff
- ✓ Ensure compliance with relevant legislation, national standards, and best practice guidelines

# Communication Policy

## SECTION 2: SCOPE

### 2 SCOPE

This policy applies to all forms of communication within and relating to the service, including interactions between staff, residents, families, and external professionals.

#### It applies to the following persons:

- ✓ All staff members, including full-time, part-time, and agency workers
- ✓ Management and leadership teams
- ✓ Residents and young people in care
- ✓ Families, guardians, and advocates
- ✓ External professionals, including social workers, healthcare providers, and inspectors
- ✓ Volunteers and students on placement

#### Types of communication covered:

- ✓ Verbal communication — face-to-face, telephone, and video calls
- ✓ Written communication — reports, care plans, emails, and handover notes
- ✓ Digital communication — messaging apps, social media, and electronic records
- ✓ Non-verbal communication — body language, visual aids, and assistive technology

# Communication Policy

## SECTION 3: PRINCIPLES

### 3 PRINCIPLES

All communication within the service should be guided by the following core principles:

- ✓ **Respect:** All communication should be respectful, considerate, and sensitive to the needs and feelings of others
- ✓ **Clarity:** Information should be communicated clearly and in a manner that is easily understood by the intended audience
- ✓ **Timeliness:** Communication should be prompt and timely, ensuring that relevant information is shared without unnecessary delay
- ✓ **Confidentiality:** All communication must adhere to data protection legislation and organisational confidentiality policies
- ✓ **Inclusivity:** Communication should be accessible and adapted to meet the individual needs of residents, including those with additional communication requirements
- ✓ **Accountability:** Staff are responsible for ensuring that their communication is professional, accurate, and recorded appropriately

# Communication Policy

## SECTION 4: RESIDENT COMMUNICATION

### 4 RESIDENT COMMUNICATION

Residents have a right to be heard and to communicate their needs, wishes, and concerns. Staff must ensure that communication with residents is:

- ✓ Age-appropriate and developmentally suitable
- ✓ Adapted to the individual's communication needs, including the use of visual aids, easy-read materials, or interpreters where required
- ✓ Supportive and encouraging, promoting the resident's confidence and self-expression
- ✓ Recorded accurately and in a timely manner in the resident's care file

#### Key practices:

- ✓ Key worker sessions should be used to facilitate open and meaningful dialogue with residents
- ✓ Residents should be informed of decisions that affect them in a manner they can understand
- ✓ Residents should be supported to participate in care planning and review meetings
- ✓ Complaints and concerns raised by residents must be taken seriously and responded to promptly

# Communication Policy

## SECTION 5: STAFF COMMUNICATION

### 5 STAFF COMMUNICATION

Effective staff communication is essential to the safe and consistent delivery of care. Staff are expected to:

- ✓ Participate in daily handover meetings to ensure continuity of care
- ✓ Complete handover notes accurately and legibly at the end of each shift
- ✓ Attend team meetings and contribute to discussions regarding resident care
- ✓ Report concerns, incidents, and significant events to the person in charge without delay
- ✓ Use professional language at all times, avoiding jargon or abbreviations that may be unclear

Communication channels for staff include:

- ✓ Daily handover meetings (verbal and written)
- ✓ Staff meetings (monthly or as required)
- ✓ Supervision sessions (individual and group)
- ✓ Email and internal messaging systems
- ✓ Notice boards and communication logs



# Communication Policy

## SECTION 6: FAMILY & ADVOCATES

### 6 COMMUNICATION WITH FAMILIES & ADVOCATES

Maintaining positive and transparent communication with families and advocates is essential to the wellbeing of residents. The service will:

- ✓ Keep families informed of significant events, changes in care, and the general wellbeing of the resident, subject to any court orders or care plan restrictions
- ✓ Facilitate family visits and phone calls in accordance with the resident's care plan
- ✓ Respond to queries and concerns from families in a timely and professional manner
- ✓ Involve families in care planning and review processes where appropriate and in the best interest of the resident
- ✓ Provide families with information about the service's policies, procedures, and complaints process

Where communication with a family member is restricted:

- ✓ Clear records must be maintained outlining the reason for the restriction
- ✓ Any restrictions must be reviewed regularly and documented in the care plan



# Communication Policy

## SECTION 7: EXTERNAL PROFESSIONALS

### 7 COMMUNICATION WITH EXTERNAL PROFESSIONALS

The service works closely with a range of external professionals, including social workers, GPs, CAMHS, therapists, guardians ad litem, and inspectors. Communication with external professionals must be:

- ✓ Professional, timely, and focused on the needs and best interests of the resident
- ✓ Documented accurately in the resident's file and shared in accordance with data protection requirements
- ✓ Coordinated through the person in charge or designated staff member to ensure consistency
- ✓ Supportive of inter-agency cooperation and information sharing protocols

#### Key external communication includes:

- ✓ Statutory reports and notifications to Tusla
- ✓ Referrals to health, education, and therapeutic services
- ✓ Participation in child-in-care reviews, case conferences, and court proceedings
- ✓ Cooperation with HIQA inspections and regulatory requirements

# Communication Policy

## SECTION 8: CONFIDENTIALITY & DATA PROTECTION

### 8 CONFIDENTIALITY & DATA PROTECTION

All communication must comply with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), the Data Protection Acts 1988–2018, and the organisation's confidentiality policy. Staff must ensure that:

- ✓ Personal and sensitive information is only shared on a need-to-know basis
- ✓ Confidential information is not discussed in public areas or in the presence of unauthorised persons
- ✓ Electronic communications are sent via secure and approved channels only
- ✓ Physical records are stored securely and access is restricted to authorised personnel
- ✓ Residents' right to privacy is upheld in all forms of communication

#### Breaches of confidentiality:

- ✓ Any breach of confidentiality must be reported immediately to the person in charge
- ✓ Breaches will be investigated and may result in disciplinary action
- ✓ All breaches must be documented and reported to the Data Protection Officer where applicable



# Communication Policy

## SECTION 9: TRAINING

### 9 TRAINING

The organisation is committed to ensuring that all staff have the knowledge and skills necessary to communicate effectively. Training will be provided in the following areas:

- ✓ Communication skills and active listening
- ✓ Report writing and record keeping
- ✓ Data protection and confidentiality
- ✓ Working with residents who have additional communication needs
- ✓ Use of assistive technology and communication aids
- ✓ Conflict resolution and de-escalation techniques

#### Training requirements:

- ✓ All new staff must complete communication training as part of their induction programme
- ✓ Refresher training will be provided annually or as required
- ✓ Training records will be maintained and reviewed as part of the supervision process

# Communication Policy

## SECTION 10: MONITORING & REVIEW

### 10 MONITORING & REVIEW

This policy will be monitored and reviewed to ensure its continued effectiveness and compliance with relevant legislation, standards, and best practice.

#### Monitoring will include:

- ✓ Regular audits of communication records, handover notes, and care plans
- ✓ Feedback from residents, families, staff, and external professionals
- ✓ Review of complaints and incidents related to communication
- ✓ Supervision and performance review discussions

#### Review schedule:

- ✓ This policy will be reviewed annually or sooner if there is a significant change in legislation, standards, or practice
- ✓ All staff will be notified of any changes to this policy and provided with updated training where necessary